

Sustaining sustainability

It's difficult to go through a week, sometimes even your average day, without coming across some content related to the climate crisis. From news bulletins on the television to newsletters in your inbox, scary headlines on websites to social media posts. Instagram and YouTube influencers may make it look easy and even glamorous, but adjusting to a sustainable lifestyle, where you reduce and eventually negate your negative impact on the environment, isn't as easy as it looks. It's a tough journey.

Despite awareness about climate change and our personal carbon footprint, old habits die hard – definitely not without a struggle. We've gotten so cosy and comfortable over so many years of living the way we've been living irresponsibly that any small change comes at the cost of convenience or your wallet.

I was trying to explain this to my school-going daughter earlier in June, when she had to work on some school projects for World Environment Day. Just because electric vehicles are more eco-friendly than carbon-emitting and pollution-causing traditional vehicles, why doesn't every car or bike owner switch to the alternative? It's a significant purchase, buying an electric car or scooter, one that most people won't make in a hurry.

Convenience is another major impediment towards getting into a sustainable lifestyle. We all know plastic pollutes, we should get rid of single-use plastic products from our daily life – even my daughter knows this, thanks to all her school projects. But if you're out making an impulse purchase or even eating snacks from a road-side vendor, something that you didn't plan you would do, will you say no to plastic bags, plastic spoons or plastic water bottles? Or will you delay your instant gratification urge in order to try and do the right thing by maybe ordering through Swiggy or Zomato to substitute your sense of guilt? Here of course you're hoping that Swiggy and Zomato are doing the right thing in ensuring you are at least minimising your carbon footprint by clicking a few check boxes in the delivery app. If the delivery guy comes on an electric vehicle to deliver your food, even better!



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We can't ignore the fact that our modern lifestyle is powered by fossil fuels for the most part. When we switch to EVs from IC-engine vehicles, for example, we shouldn't forget that we are ultimately burning coal to get that electricity into our EVs – at least here in India. We are restricting the source of pollution and increasing efficiency of power generation at the source, which is an important thing to do. As solar, wind and other renewable energy tech gets advanced, we will benefit as a people. Currently, however, we are in a transition phase, something we shouldn't forget. There's going to be a lot of cost-to-convenience inertia that will hold us from taking the right step forward, but we should keep making progress in the right direction and keep gathering momentum.

The good news is that there's a lot of incentive being created for everyone to get more sustainable in their life choices. For example, all big-tech companies have 100 per cent net zero emissions goals that they're planning to achieve between 2030 to 2050. What this means is that the tech gadgets they produce for all of us will become more sustainable over the next 25 years. Yes, in the short term, a lot of things won't make sense – like brands choosing not to include charging cables in phones (for which you should read this month's column from Soham) – but ultimately consumer behaviour is being forced to shift towards embracing more sustainable choices.

I'll give you the same advice I gave my daughter, when we were talking about making eco-friendly choices in our lives. We can't ignore the fact that we can make more informed choices in our day-to-day life, from choosing whether to order plastic spoons with our meal deliveries all the way to living off-grid in a 100 per cent sustainable farmstead where we generate our own electricity, grow our own food, and recycle our waste. Let's be realistic with what we have and what we can do, that living a sustainable lifestyle is in fact a marathon not a race. Let's not make being sustainable an unsustainable goal. **d**